Storycast

Research & Planning

An accessible audio and video storytelling microsite
Semantic HTML5 · Sass · CSS Grid and Flexbox · vanilla JavaScript

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1. Project brief

StoryCast is a three-page microsite that showcases short audio and video stories. The assignment asks for semantic HTML5, Sass, responsive layouts with Grid and Flexbox (including a container-queried component), WCAG 2.1 AA accessibility, and no frameworks. This document records the research and planning that came before the code: who the site is for, what accessibility requires for media, and how the information architecture and layouts follow from that.

2. Research approach

This research draws on published standards and large-scale accessibility data to decide what the site must do. No interviews, surveys or usability sessions with real users were carried out for this document. The audience profiles below are therefore working hypotheses, and Section 7 sets out how to test them.

Sources used:
• W3C, Web Content Accessibility Guidelines (WCAG) 2.1, success criteria 1.1.1, 1.2.1 to 1.2.5,
1.3.1, 1.4.1 to 1.4.12, 2.1.1, 2.2.2, 2.4.1 to 2.4.7, 3.1.1 and 4.1.2.
• W3C Web Accessibility Initiative, Making Audio and Video Media Accessible: guidance on captions, transcripts and audio description.
• WebAIM, The WebAIM Million (2026 edition, data collected February 2026): automated analysis

of one million home pages.
• MDN Web Docs: the <track> element, WebVTT, and CSS container queries.

3. Findings

3.1 Most sites still fail the basics

The 2026 WebAIM Million found detectable WCAG 2 failures on 95.9% of home pages, averaging 56.1 errors per page. The most common failures are exactly the ones a small, carefully built site can avoid completely.

Common failure (WebAIM 2026):

1. Low contrast text: In storycast, all colour pairs are defined as tokens and checked by a script (24 of 24 pass AA).
2. Missing alternative text: Storycast ensures decorative art has alt=""; informative cover art has a written description.
3. Missing form input labels: The site has no forms. The only inputs (speed select, follow checkbox) have visible labels.
4. Empty links: Every link has visible text; whole-card links use the story title as the link text

3.2 What media accessibility requires

Audio and video are where accessibility most often breaks. WCAG 2.1 sets out what StoryCast has to provide for prerecorded media:

WCAG 2.1 criterion	Level	Requirement	Storycast response
1.2.1 Audio-only and video-only	A	A text or audio alternative for prerecorded audio-only content.	Full transcript beside every story.
1.2.2 Captions (prerecorded)	A	Captions for audio in synchronised media.	WebVTT captions track on video; live caption line for

			audio.
1.2.3 / 1.2.5 Audio description	A / AA	Describe important visual information not in the audio track.	Sample video visuals are decorative; a text description is provided. Real footage needs a description track.
1.4.2 Audio control	A	No audio that plays automatically for more than 3 seconds without a way to stop it.	Nothing autoplays.
2.1.1 Keyboard	A	All functionality available from a keyboard.	Native media controls; buttons and links only
1.4.10 Reflow	AA	No two-dimensional scrolling at 320 CSS px.	Fluid Grid/Flex layouts, tested at 320px

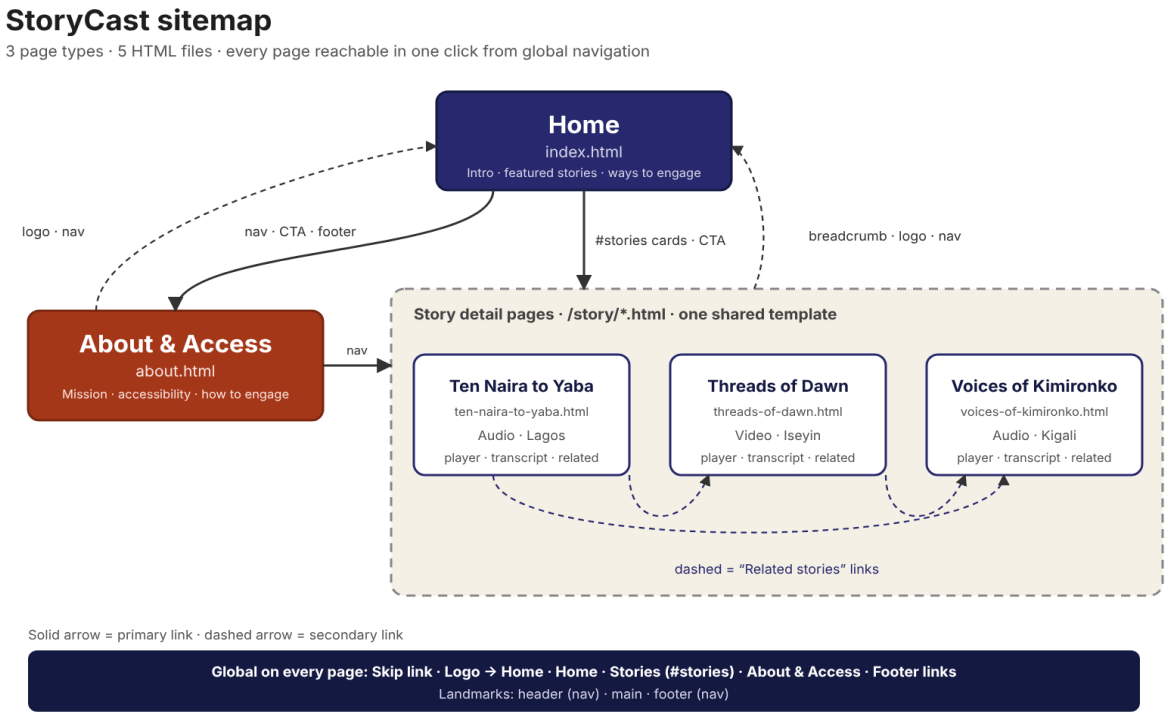
3.3 Design principles that follow

- Content first, media second. The transcript is part of the page, not a link to a separate file.
- Native before custom. Use the browser's own <audio> and <video> controls, which are keyboard accessible and familiar, rather than building a custom player.
- Never use colour alone. Media type, current page and the active transcript line are shown with words, underlines and bars as well as colour.
- Progressive enhancement. Everything important works without JavaScript; scripts only add convenience.
- Respect user settings. Honour reduced motion, text size and zoom.

4. Information architecture

StoryCast is deliberately small. Three page types keep the structure shallow, so any page is one click from the global navigation.

4.1.1 Sitemap



4.1.2 Wireframes/Mockups:

Link: [Figma Wireframes]

5. Navigation model

Global navigation (every page): Home, Stories, About & Access. "Stories" jumps to the featured cards on Home and is marked as the current section on story pages.

• Skip link is the first tab stop on every page.

• Breadcrumb on story pages (Home / Stories / title) for orientation.

• Related stories on every story page keep people moving between stories without going back.

• Footer navigation repeats the essentials and links to the source code.

6. Visual design direction

The look is warm and editorial, to suit storytelling: a paper-toned background, a serif display face for headings and a clean system sans for body text, with deep indigo and clay red drawn from woven cloth and street colour. Amber is reserved for focus and emphasis on dark surfaces.

7. Validation plan and open items

The designs have not yet been tested with real people. Recommended next steps:

• Recruit a small group that includes people who use captions, screen readers and keyboard-only navigation.

• Give each person tasks: find and play a story; find the transcript; jump to a specific moment; find the accessibility information; change playback speed.

• Record where people hesitate or fail, fix, and retest. Add the findings to this document.

• Replace the synthetic sample narration with real recordings and have a person review the captions for accuracy.

• Figma: import the SVG wireframes from docs/wireframes/, build the high-fidelity mockups at 1280px and 390px using the tokens in Section 6, and add both links to the README.

8. References

• W3C. Web Content Accessibility Guidelines (WCAG) 2.1. https://www.w3.org/TR/WCAG21/

• W3C WAI. Making Audio and Video Media Accessible. https://www.w3.org/WAI/media/av/

• WebAIM. The WebAIM Million (2026). https://webaim.org/projects/million/

• MDN Web Docs. CSS container queries. https://developer.mozilla.org/en-US/docs/Web/CSS/CSS_containment/Container_queries

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